

Organizational Systems — Module 07:

Communication — Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on organizational communication, model alignment, and information architecture.

1. How does framing communication as "model alignment" change how you think about meetings, emails, and reports?
2. What is "common ground" and why is it a prerequisite for efficient organizational communication? What happens when common ground is absent?
3. Spotify's squad-tribe-chapter-guild model creates multiple overlapping communication channels. Using Active Inference, explain why this redundancy is valuable rather than wasteful.
4. Information silos are the most cited communication failure in organizations. Using the Active Inference framework, provide a more precise diagnosis: What exactly fails when teams stop sharing information?
5. Why does information get distorted as it moves up the organizational hierarchy? What mental models and incentive structures cause this signal degradation?
6. What is the difference between "broadcasting information" (top-down) and "aligning models" (bidirectional)? Which is more common in your experience? Which is more effective?
7. How do **boundary objects** (shared documents, prototypes, dashboards) enable communication between specialists who have different generative models?
8. When does communication become pathological? How would you diagnose whether an organization has too many meetings versus too few?

9. Email overload is a universal complaint. Using the precision and relevance concepts from Active Inference, explain why most organizational email is low-precision noise rather than high-precision signal.
10. How does organizational culture affect communication patterns? Compare the communication norms of a military organization with those of a design agency.
11. Map the formal and informal communication channels in your organization. Where does the formal structure fail, and where does the informal network compensate?
12. Identify a recent miscommunication in your organization and diagnose it as a model alignment failure. Which agents had incompatible models? What common ground was missing?
13. Design an optimal meeting cadence for your team. For each meeting, specify: purpose (model sharing, belief updating, or action coordination), frequency, attendees, and success criteria.
14. Your organization is planning a major strategic change. Design a communication plan that ensures all agents (at all levels) update their generative models to align with the new strategy.
15. Remote/hybrid work has disrupted many organizations' informal communication channels. Using the concepts from this module, assess what was lost and design specific replacements.
16. A merger requires aligning the generative models of two distinct organizational cultures. Design a 90-day communication integration plan that builds common ground.
17. Your organization has a brilliant strategy document that nobody reads. Diagnose this communication failure and propose alternatives that would achieve actual model alignment.
18. How should the communication system differ between a crisis (high uncertainty, rapid model updating required) and steady-state operations (low uncertainty, incremental updates)?

19. Design a "communication audit" that evaluates whether your organization's information architecture is adequate. What metrics would you measure?
20. Many organizations rely on "town halls" and "all-hands meetings" as primary communication vehicles. Using the Active Inference framework, evaluate the effectiveness of these formats. Under what conditions do they succeed, and when do they fail?